party that was formed in 2017 and fought in the NA-120 by-elections, includes representatives and members that are on international lists of most wanted terrorists. The country has on several occasions also been held hostage by right-wing religious groups such as the Tehreek-e-Labbaik Ya Rasool Allah (TLYR or TLP) which together with the Tehreek-e-Khatm-e-Nabuwwat and the Sunni Tehreek Pakistan launched a countrywide three-week protest that ended in November 2017 with the state giving in to the demands of the protestors. The protest was against an amendment made to a clause in the Elections Bill 2017 that relates to the finality of the Prophet of Islam, called the 'Khatm-e-Nabuwwat oath', in which the phrase 'I solemnly swear' was replaced by 'the words "I believe"' (Pakistan Today 2017a). While the law minister defended his reasons for changing these words, clearly stating that it by no means challenged or repealed the 'Khatm-e-Nabuwwat laws' and the Parliament eventually decided that there had been a 'clerical error' and it should be reverted back to the original phrase, the protestors nonetheless demanded that the law minister be sacked. The protestors continued their protests, illegally taking over major cities of Pakistan, ignoring orders from the judiciary to end the protests and further protesting when their leaders and members were arrested, damaging property as well as beating up policemen. With the army refusing to step in at the request of the government, an operation was launched by the government (reminiscent of the disastrous Lal Masjid operation in 2007), which resulted in the killing of six individuals, with the army becoming a mediator between the government and the TLYR protestors and the government caving in to the demands of the protestors (see Chapter 4). Not only was the resignation of the law minister a sign of a weak state giving into these protestors, but the amount of time given to the Faizabad protestors further begs the question whether the Pakistani state is simply paying lip service to the idea of a national narrative against extremism. This is especially questionable in instances where rights activists are immediately stopped from protesting, as was evident in the protest organized by the social activist group FixIT in Karachi at the same time as the Faizabad protest, to raise awareness about the 'poor quality of education'; the protest ended within hours as the police 'used a water-cannon and tear gas to disperse the crowd' (Pakistan Today 2017b). While FixIT protestors were arrested, TLYR announced that it would run for the 2018 elections.

Another example is the security state's treatment of the Pashtun Tahafuz Movement (PTM). The PTM provides the ideal counternarrative to extremism; it is led by young citizens from Waziristan and FATA demanding their rights as Pakistanis. Instead of supporting and promoting this organic narrative, the counternarrative of the security state has been unable to move beyond its good